

A device that prints, faxes, and copies our documents? We're all for one! Join us as we go under the hood of 18 inkjet multi-functional devices

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One device, many functions, is the core philosophy driving innovation today. Consumers want more from a single device—and manufacturers are only too happy to oblige—at times even *creating* the need. Printers that can scan are preferred over vanilla printers. It makes more sense to have a copier on the device even if it cannot compete in quality or economy with standalone photocopiers. You now need not get your photos scanned at your “DTP Centre”—the scan quality of most of these MFDs is good enough to convert your old photographs into digital data.

The 18 inkjet Multi-Functional Devices (MFDs) we received from Brother, Canon, Epson, HP and Lexmark ranged from the bare-bones basics to those with photo-quality printers. Needless to say, the price disparity was huge, and it would not make sense to compare a Rs 4,000 MFD to one that costs Rs 12,000. For this test, therefore, we made a broad classification based on their photo-printing capability. All non-photo class MFDs were looked at as home solutions, while photo-quality MFDs were segregated, based on price, into Office and Professional categories.

Fourteen of the 18 MFDs fell under the photo-printing bracket, and those that cost below Rs 10,000 are primarily targeted at office users. The ones on the other side of the five-figure mark are for imaging enthusiasts and for heavy office printing, with bulk printing and networking capabilities.

FOR HOME USE (NON-PHOTO MFDs) Performance

Mostly used for black and white printouts, an occasional colour print that is not all-important, and the copy function used when in a tearing hurry—that sums up the functionality of this category. The Lexmark X3350, Epson CX3700, Brother MFC-3240C, and the HP Officejet 4355 All-in-One make up this bracket. Colour printing is certainly not the strong point here, save for the 4355. Even black ink printing is not up to the mark on the Lexmark and the Epson. This is especially telling with small point size text. The HP 4355 and the Brother 3240C offer the best quality amongst the four here.

Even though these devices are classified as non-photo printing MFDs, we still carried out a photo print test just to see whether they managed vivid colour prints. We were in for a pleasant surprise, with the 4355 and the 3240C giving us a rather good printout. In fact, the photo quality of the 3240C is better than its brother, the Brother MFC-115C, which is marked as a photo printer! The HP Officejet 4355 can give some photo printing MFDs a run for their money. The CX3700 managed to give an acceptable print, but the same can't be said about the X3350—it churned out a speckled image that had a “burnt” kind of effect.

Print quality, time taken to print, and ink consumption are the variables in the printing equation. Different printers/MFDs find different points of balance under different modes—Draft or Fast, Normal, and Best or Fine. The HP 4355 took a reasonable 15 seconds for the first print in Draft mode and 23 in Normal. The 3240C took the longest to print on the average, with a draft text coming at 23 seconds; a full A4 photo test print took over 16 minutes.

The colour copy quality was satisfactory with the Epson CX3700 and HP Officejet 4355, which took a leisurely 97 and 72 seconds respectively to copy an A4 document composed of text and graphics. The Lexmark X3350 and Brother MFC-3240C were quicker, taking just about half the time as the Epson, but the pace is of no avail as the quality leaves a lot to be desired. The black and white print copy was acceptable on all the MFDs, with the 3240C spitting out something that was a little smudged.

Build Quality And Ease Of Use

The CX3700 was missing a display, which is surprising, given its price of Rs 5,999—Rs 1,000 more than that of the Lexmark X3350. The X3350 and 3240C have a basic single-colour display, making life that much simpler for the user, especially during troubleshooting.

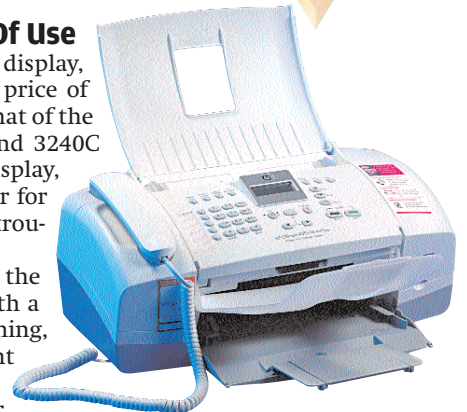
The lack of a display on the CX3700 is compensated for with a dedicated button for head cleaning, which doubles up to get the print head into an accessible position to replace the cartridges. Error indication is by way of two warning lights, one for a “General Error”—that is just as descriptive as the Epson gets—and the other for low/no ink. The paper feed and output trays fold in neatly, leaving no protruding parts while not being used.

The X3350 is the most inexpensive MFD in this category at Rs 4,999. Unfortunately, this shows in the fit and finish. There is no place for the paper feed tray to slot into while not in use, and as a result, it sits awkwardly on the cover. The buttons are noisy, too.

The HP 4355 has plastic trays jutting out everywhere. It is difficult to close the output tray once you have the face-plate installed. The Brother MFC-3240C and the Epson CX3700 had good build qualities.

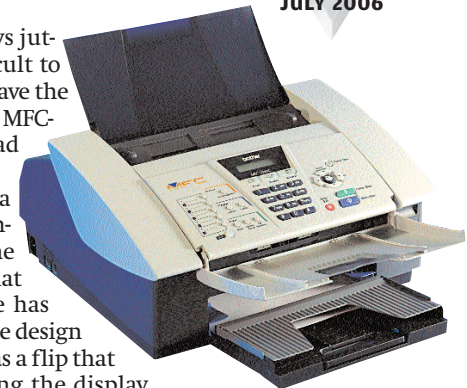
The HP 4355 doubles up as a phone as well—and why not, considering it already uses the phone line to fax. Now this is an MFD that is truly multifunctional. Space has definitely been the priority in the design of the 4355—it is compact and has a flip that covers the buttons while leaving the display exposed. However, with all flaps and trays open, it

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HP Officejet 4355 All-in-One

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Brother MFC-3240C